

THE LAST STEP

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Draft #1

FADE IN

INT.COLLEGE BUILDING - MORNING

A vast, quiet interior.

A LONG FLIGHT OF STAIRS stretches upward, disappearing out of frame.

At the bottom stands a COLLEGE BOY.

Small against the space.

He looks up at the staircase.

A moment.

He breathes in.

AARAV(V.O.)

(calm, reflective)

Every journey begins somewhere.

Mine began with a step I was afraid to take.

He steps forward.

INT. STAIRCASE - LOWER STEPS - CONTINUOUS

His foot lands on the first step.

The sound echoes.

He climbs one... then another.

INT.ROOM - NIGHT (FLASHBACK)

A laptop screen playing makeup tutorial videos.

His eyes were watching closely.

A notebook filled with notes.

Makeup products near his laptop.

He uses the products trying to learn.

INT.STAIRCASE - MID LEVEL - DAY

Footsteps echo louder now.

He walks with a cold face.

INT.COLLEGE CLASSROOM - DAY (FLASHBACK)

Students waiting for class.

Noise. Casual chatter.

AARAV sits quietly.

He opens his bag.

Inside - makeup brushes slightly visible.

A FRIEND notices.

He pulls one out dramatically.

FRIEND

Bro... What is this?

Others turn.

Another student grabs a palette.

CLASSMATE

Wait... is this makeup?

Laughter spreads.

Phones come out.

Someone pretends to apply lipstick mockingly.

CLASSMATE 2

Machan, next heroine ready ah?

More laughter.

Someone records a video.

AARAV freezes.

Embarrassment rising.

A BOY says loudly—

CLASSMATE 3

Why are you doing girls' stuff?

Silence hits harder than laughter.

Camera on Aarav.

Hands tightening.

Across the room –

A GIRL watches.

Not laughing.

Just observing.

A long beat.

AARAV slowly stands.

Takes back his brushes.

Look directly at them.

INT.STAIRCASE – HALFWAY POINT

He slows.

Breathing heavier.

INT.ROOM – NIGHT

His thumb is deleting photos from his phone.

A paused tutorial video.

The phone screen going dark

Silence.

INT.STAIRCASE – UPPER STEPS – CONTINUOUS

He walks again.

Then up.

A long beat.

He stands.

INT.ROOM - EVENING

He sits alone at a desk.

Still.

Suddenly -

A MALE AUTHORITY FIGURE'S HANDS enter frame.

We NEVER see the face.

Hands slamming a notebook shut.

Fingers pointing sharply.

AUTHORITY (O.S.)

What are you doing with all this?

You're here to study.

Not for these distractions which are not meant for you.

AUTHORITY (CONT'D)

Focus on what actually matters.

The hands withdraw.

CUT TO:

INT.STAIRCASE - UPPER STEPS - CONTINUOUS

He stands on a step.

The words echo faintly in his head.

Silence.

He straightens his back.

Take the next step.

INT. STAIRCASE - FINAL STEP - EVENING

He reaches the last step.

Complete silence.

Ahead: a long, empty hallway.

Then walks forward.

INT. HALLWAY - CONTINUOUS

His footsteps echo evenly.

He reaches a RIGHT TURN.

As he turns -

MATCH CUT TO:

INT. GRAND STAGE - DAY

The hallway seamlessly transforms into a STAGE.

Bright lights.

No audience visible.

MC

(cheerfully)

AND THE BEST MAKEUP ARTIST GOES TO MR.AARAV

He steps forward.

Takes the trophy.

His hands are steady.

He exhales.

Peaceful.

AARAV(V.O.)

(soft smile)

So... how do you think I ended up here?

CUT TO BLACK.

SMASH CUT TO:

FLASHBACK SEQUENCE

INT. ROOM - NIGHT

A dim desk lamp.

Mirror placed against a stack of books.

Makeup products scattered.

AARAV applies eyeliner.

His hand shakes.

The line smudges.

He exhales sharply.

Wipes it off.

Tries again.

Still wrong.

Frustrated, he almost throws the pencil.

He stops.

Looks at his reflection.

Silence.

He takes a deep breath.

Tries again.

Cleaner this time.

Not perfect.

But better.

A small smile forms.

INT. COLLEGE CLASSROOM - DAY

AARAV

It's makeup.

And yeah... I like doing it.

The room quiets slight
Confidence mixed with fear.

AARAV (CONT'D)

That's it.

He sits down again.

No background music.

Just silence.

The girl continues looking at him – impressed.

INT. COLLEGE CORRIDOR – NEXT DAY

AARAV walks alone.

The GIRL approaches.

GIRL

Hey... there's a cultural fest tomorrow.
I'm performing.
I don't really know how to do makeup.
Can you help me?

He's stunned.

AARAV

Me?

She smiles.

GIRL

Yeah. You.

A small, genuine smile appears on his face.

INT. BACKSTAGE - CULTURAL FEST - DAY

Crowded. Noisy.

The girl sits in front of Aarav.

He takes a deep breath.

Apply foundation carefully.

Blends. Focused.

Sharp eyeliner.

His hands are steady now.

She checks herself in the mirror.

Her eyes widened.

GIRL

Oh my god... this is amazing.

Nearby performers notice.

(People)

"Who did her makeup?"

She points at Aarav.

For the first time — appreciation.

INT. ROOM - NIGHT

Phone in his hand.

Instagram profile open.

Low likes. A few mocking comments.

He presses DELETE ACCOUNT.

Confirmation screen appears.

His thumb hovers.

Silence.

PING.

A new DM.

"Hi. I saw your work. It's really impressive.
Would you like to collaborate for an event?"

He freezes.

Heart pounding.

Slowly... he pulls his thumb away from DELETE.

Instead—

He types:

"Thank you. I'd love to."

INT. ROOM - EVENING

An AUTHORITY FIGURE'S hands slam a notebook shut.

AUTHORITY (O.S.)

What are you doing with all this?

You're here to study.

Focus on what actually matters.

Silence.

AARAV looks at the closed notebook.

Slowly...

He opens it again.

Inside: makeup, face charts and designs.

He picks up a pencil.

Continues sketching.

AARAV

(quiet but firm)

This matters.

The authority figure exists.

QUICK MONTAGE:

- Late nights practicing on himself
- Doing makeup for small college events
- Followers increasing
- First payment notification
- Rejection email
- Bigger backstage opportunities
- His name printed on a small event poster

Music builds.

CUT TO:

BACK TO PRESENT

INT. GRAND STAGE - DAY

Applause.

AARAV stands at the mic, trophy in hand.

AARAV

Some steps are taken in doubt.
Some are in fear.
Some in silence.

A small breath.

AARAV (CONT'D)

We grow up seeing people do great things...
but when someone close to us chooses a different path...

suddenly it becomes wrong.

A small smile.

AARAV (CONT'D)

I've seen people celebrate artists on screen...
and laugh at one sitting next to them.

A beat.

AARAV (CONT'D)

There will always be people who judge you.
Friends.
Society.
Sometimes even family.

But when the lights go off...
they don't walk your journey.

You do.

He looks at the trophy.

AARAV (CONT'D)

I almost stopped...
because I was afraid of what people would say.
I'm glad I chose to listen to myself instead.

A calm breath.

AARAV (CONT'D)

Because if you don't stop...

the last step
will always be worth it.

CUT TO BLACK